



# Newsletter

April 2026

From the Editor – Olwyn Alexander – Welcome to the April 2026 newsletter.

Following the successful series of refresher walks led by guides in 2024 & 2025, a programme of similar walks is being offered for 2026. These will take place in June & July with two morning and two afternoon walks.

Tuesday 9th June 2.30 pm Rosemary Mann *Darwin's Edinburgh*. Start at the plaque to Darwin on the rear of NMS, where Lothian Street meets West College Street.

Tuesday 16th June 10.30am Jim Eunson *Southern Extensions to the Old Town*. Start at Infirmary Street and end in George Square.

Tuesday 23rd June 10.30 am Eric Melvin *John Kay's Edinburgh Folk* start at the equestrian statue of King Charles behind St Giles Cathedral.

Thursday 2nd July 3.45pm Tom Johnston *Legal Edinburgh*. Start at the Witches Well at the entrance to the Esplanade

## Annual General Meeting

The Annual General Meeting was held in the European Room of the City Chambers on 18<sup>th</sup> March with 21 guides present, chaired by Vice-Chair Val Baker. Jim Eunson, Eric Melvin and Ken Young provided a display of rare books.

Over the past year the committee has aimed to restore face-to-face contact for guides with informal meetup events in November 2025 and January 2026. At the most recent events guides contributed books to share and this prompted the book display at the AGM. The Chair welcomed two new guides, Fiona Watt and Jock Anderson to the committee.

Treasurer, Jim Eunson, reported that the balance at the end of 2025 was £4399, a decrease on last year, but this was set against the fact that two years' worth of social function expenditure had occurred in 2025, with other one-off costs. The Committee had agreed to increase the rate for private tours to £10 per person.

Four new guides, Stuart Grieve, Derek Stryjski, Jacqui Court-Brown and Moira Calderwood were presented with their badges by the Deputy Lord Provost,



Lesley Cameron. Rosemary Mann was not present. It was noted that Gordon Drysdale and Fiona Brownlee have stepped back as guides.

The Deputy Lord Provost gave a charmingly informal speech, contrasting the professional approach of Edinburgh Festival Guides to leaders of other tour groups who use the forecourt of the City Chambers. She offered to connect EFVGA with the International Conference Centre and as the preferred group for VIP tours.

# Newsletter

## Year-round Custom Tours

Elspeth McLean reported on the private tours in 2025. This was another good year, with a marked uplift from 2024. We had 33 private walks booked for a total of 243 people. Continuing the trend of recent years, 27 private tours were with people from North America, with 2 Canadian & the rest USA, followed by 3 International tours, 2 from Europe (Germany) and 1 from UK. These tours were taken by 18 different guides, 11 of whom were not committee members.

There were two large tours: an international conference taking place in April, for Teachers of English as a Foreign Language, who enjoyed a presentation and walking tours on 2 evenings with 90 delegates taking part. There was the traditional SPICE tour in August with 50 participants taking a tour of the Upper Royal Mile.

Looking ahead, we have 6 private tours booked in advance, the largest of which is in April when we welcome a group of 135 musicians and friends from the Netherlands. The orchestra, Koninklijke Stadsharmonie Phileutonia, is from Helmond and each year the group makes an excursion to a musical city to perform with a local orchestra. Guides leading the tour groups have been offered the chance to attend this concert the evening before in the Queen's Hall.

Finally, a huge thank you to all those guides who have volunteered and been involved in taking private tour groups throughout the year. Without so many guides coming forward, we would not be able to take these large group walks.

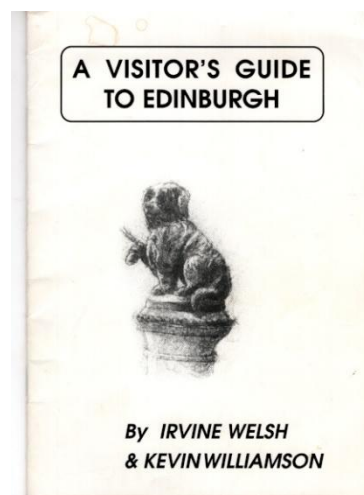
Elspeth has stepped down from the committee and John Masson will curate the private tours. Elspeth thanked John for stepping in quickly when she was unavailable. She was sure he would do an excellent job going forward.

## Book Marks

Following the book sharing sessions at the recent informal meetup events and the book display at the AGM, we are pleased to introduce a new section for book reviews in the newsletter.

Do you have a book that has helped you to explore the history of Edinburgh? Please get in touch if you would like to submit a review. In this first outing, Jim Eunson showcases one of the more unusual guides to Edinburgh in his collection and the editor gives a personal response to a novel that centres on Thomas Weir.

### A Visitor's Guide To Edinburgh



At first glance this little book about Edinburgh doesn't look anything special, with a picture of the ubiquitous Greyfriars Bobby on the front. Then you see that the authors are Irvine Welsh

and Kevin Williamson.

It dates from 1993; my copy is the 1995 reprint. That means it was contemporary with the 1993 appearance of *Trainspotting* (the book not the film). It says that 'most visitors' guidebooks concentrate far too heavily on the city centre. This one concentrates on wonderful places such as Leith, Warriston and Crewe Toll'. Reading it now, it is surprising how many of the places mentioned are gone forever. The eccentric choice of the first three sights to see, Gordon Marshall's Gentleman's Hairdresser and Greeting Card Shop in West Maitland Street, Old Scotland in

# Newsletter

Pictures in Brunswick Street and Borland's Darts and Television Shop in Croall Place, are all now closed. Likewise the next three; in fact one of the only survivors is Warriston Crematorium in Warriston Road. As the guide says of it:

'If the worst comes to the worst for visitors, then their next-of-kins could do worse than choose Warriston as their final place of rest'

We then reach 'the much sought-after district of Crewe Toll' then Granton Beach, off Ferry Road. It is interesting reading this now as the joke has gone from the description. The photo is an obvious fake, but the description of the beach is less of a comic exaggeration now than it would have been when it was written.

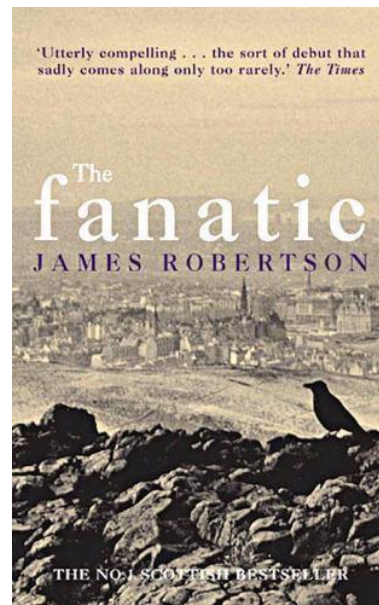
The best suggestion in the book for 'one of the truly great Edinburgh walks' is Ferry Road. 'The best time to see it in all its glory is to start your stroll at midnight on a Friday or Saturday and wander its length beneath the beautiful and historic yellow neon street lights' (Even they have gone now.) Perhaps the EFVGA could offer this? (or perhaps not)

So it is more of an interesting memorial to the Edinburgh of Welsh's book *Trainspotting* than a useful guide, because the vast majority of the odd shops have now closed, and most of the jokes are rather flat.

## The Fanatic by James Robertson

Some guides may tell the story of Major Thomas Weir, known in his lifetime as 'angelical Thomas', and his sister Jean, who both confessed to dark practices and witchcraft at the end of their lives for which they were burned at the stake or hanged. Major Weir's ghost is said to haunt the West Bow, where the pair lived, wearing a black cloak and hat and carrying a long staff. Legend has it that the devil comes looking for the Weirs riding a dark horse.

I've always had difficulty telling this story in a convincing way as I don't believe in ghosts and I've wondered about the historical facts. Was Major Weir mentally unwell at the end of his life, which caused him to make a confession that no-one at first believed? I recently came across a novel by James Robertson, *The Fanatic*, which explores the period towards the end of 17<sup>th</sup> century, and builds a picture of Major Weir in relation to the religious and political struggles of his time.



*The Fanatic* deals with three main characters, James Mitchel, a Covenanter who attempted to assassinate Andrew Sharp the Archbishop of St Andrews, Major Thomas Weir, an acquaintance of Mitchel,

and Andrew Carlin, a present-day historian researching Major Weir in order to impersonate him in a ghost tour. Interleaving the stories of these three characters enables Robertson to explore religious fanaticism and in particular the notion of being one of the elect, those who are already chosen for heaven. Mitchel is uncertain if he is 'saved' whereas Thomas Weir is certain, both for himself and for Mitchel, that they have grace. Robertson asks the reader to consider the logical conclusion of this belief: Major Weir believes the urges within him come from God but understands later that they are sent by the Devil.

Robertson uses the modern-day historian Carlin, (a Scots term for a witch), to



# Newsletter

explore historical sources that reveal that Major Weir's confessions of bestiality and incest with his sister were supported by witness testimonies. There is no doubt he was guilty of these crimes. However, I wonder if casting the Weirs as witches and then ghosts serves to cover up worse crimes that might have been thought shocking for delicate, e.g. Victorian, sensibilities.

Whether we regard this book as fictionalised history or historical fiction, I found it useful for understanding the values of the time and the motivation behind the stories we tell today.

## Image teaser



This image shows the carving by Alexander Mylne, carved in 1637 when he was only 24 years old. It had the city coat of arms with maiden, deer and castle in the centre. The large statue on the left is Justice, holding weighing scales with which to judge the rights & wrongs. The statue on the right is Mercy, holding a crown to symbolise God's mercy. It was originally positioned above the door to the Parliament Building but was removed and thrown away in 1824. It was found on a rubbish tip and relocated to 37 Drummond Place, before being recovered in 1909 and placed at the back of Old Parliament Hall.

## The next challenge



This circular tower was originally one of four angle turrets in the wall of a castle, probably built in the late 16th or early 17th century. The former castle no longer exists but nearby stables attest to this being the country residence of a wealthy landowner.

## Spotlight on guides

Gill Davidson

Gill Davidson was born in Jamaica where her father was stationed during WWII in the Royal Army Dental Corps. She grew up in Montrose and came to Edinburgh to train as a nurse at the Royal Infirmary. The family had a strong connection to the Edinburgh Festival as her grandfather served as an accountant for the first Festival in 1947. Her parents came to Festival events every year.

*How long have you been a guide and what prompted you to start?*

My grandfather took me on a tour of the Royal Mile when I was six but the only thing I remember was the story of the tenement collapse and the wee boy shouting 'Heave awa' lads I'm no deid yet'. I've always had a love of history so when I heard about the Edinburgh Festival Voluntary Guides, I thought I'd like to get involved. I took about a year to prepare and passed the assessment in November 2001. When I was assessed, I was so nervous that I dried up at one point. Then later, when we went to Milne's Court, which I knew really well, the assessor skipped over that and I missed a chance to show what I knew!

# Newsletter

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*What is the strangest thing that has happened to you on a walk?*

I once hosted a couple from New Zealand, who had literally just arrived and not even booked into their hotel. It was a pouring wet day so we went into the Radisson Blue Hotel. They said, 'Please could you explain the difference in church history between England and Scotland'. That was a real challenge but I think I managed to cope. They were both lawyers and were really interested in getting the facts right.

Another time, I was waiting for a tour at the City Chambers when suddenly a woman collapsed. Because I was a nurse, I rushed forward to help. We made her comfortable as her family were just arriving. It was one of those automatic moments where you don't have to think but just react instinctively, as you've always done. I haven't had any casualties on my actual walks.

*Do you have a favourite Royal Mile character or place that you like to visit?*

Definitely Milnes Court because there is so much to say there. It brings in a lot of Edinburgh's history: there's the smuggling across the Nor' Loch, and I talk about how caddies brought water, and the stench from 'gardy loo'. Then you've got the architecture because the reconstruction won an award. You can point out the little windows where the men chalked their hair and the curved railings made to cope with ladies fashions. Also it's off the beaten track and away from the busy-ness of the High Street. Another place I love which I can only go to during the week is Parliament House, which is good for a rainy day. It's fascinating to see the lawyers walking up and down with their mobile phones.

*What's the most rewarding aspect of being a guide?*

I feel Edinburgh is such a great place to live that one of my motivations was to

give something back to the City so I love being able to show people what a wonderful place Edinburgh is and talk about its history. And for me personally, it's kept me interested and given me things to read and learn. Also my Grandad would be proud to think that one of his granddaughters was carrying on the tradition and doing things for the Festival.

*What advice would you give to new guides?*

The most important thing about guiding is being able to communicate with such a wide range of people with different interests, different personalities or different languages and also somehow to involve them so they feel that they are part of it.

I think one of the lovely things about the EFVGA is that we've been going since the very first Festival so there's that sense of continuity, even through Covid. The fact that we volunteer to do it I also think is important. – long may we last.

## Edinburgh Local Heritage Network (ELHN)

The Edinburgh Local Heritage Network (ELHN) was launched by the Lord Provost Robert Aldridge in May 2023 with the aim of encouraging collaboration and knowledge sharing between local heritage groups and Council services such as Archives, Libraries, and Museums and Galleries. The Members of the Network were partners in *Edinburgh 900*, celebrating the founding of Edinburgh as a Royal Burgh by King David in 1125.

ELHN holds quarterly meetings to continue its aims beyond this important anniversary. One key agenda item at a December meeting was the strategy for allocating the Visitor Levy Fund (the tourist tax) to give benefit to tourists as well as residents. The Council has agreed to spend £5 million on affordable homes,

# Newsletter

moving households out of temporary B&B accommodation and returning this to its original use for short term lets. A further £1.7 million will be spent over three years to support local community groups to tell their stories, with £300,000 for administrative costs.

While EFVGA might not bid directly for project funding, there is an opportunity to take part in the Local Heritage Fair, which this year will be held in September.

## The Great Wizard of the North

Sir Walter Scott came to be known as the 'Wizard of the North' on account of his ability to magically transform fiction into something fresh and new. Scott is said to have bestowed his nickname on John Henry Anderson (b.1814–d.1874) from Aberdeen, a professional magician who performed as The Great Wizard of the North. Anderson is credited with helping bring the art of magic from street performances into theatres and presenting magic to entertain the audience. One of our Festival Guides, Jock Anderson, believes he has a family connection to John Henry. Inspired by a BBC news item (The Scottish magician who inspired the great Houdini - BBC News), Jock has rekindled his efforts to connect to his famous forebear.

Jock emigrated from Aberdeen to New Zealand with his parents when he was 11. He remembers particular items from a store cupboard in their Clifton Road house that had to be abandoned for the voyage. These included a bust of The Wizard, a top hat and gloves, claimed to belong to John Henry, a leather-bound family bible, which contained a family tree, together with three Gurkha knives and a carriage riding whip. Jock thinks these might have been donated to Aberdeen Museum and hopes he can still locate them.

John Henry Anderson was born in 1814 and orphaned when he was ten. He attached himself to a travelling theatre company and began performing magic tricks at age 17. He performed a successful magic show at the home of Lord Panmure, a Scottish landowner and patron of the arts. This success inspired him to put together a touring show and in 1840, he moved to London and opened the New Strand Theatre. In 1845, he built the City Theatre in Glasgow but this burned down after only 4 months. In spite of this setback, he began touring his shows through Europe to St Petersburg, where he performed for Czar Nicholas. In 1849, he returned to London and gave a command performance for Queen Victoria and Prince Albert.

John Henry's innovative approach to his shows was not simply to perform illusions that the audience couldn't explain but to make sure his tricks entertained and delighted his audience. He was one of the early magicians to popularise pulling a rabbit from a hat and was famous in his lifetime for the Bullet Catch illusion, in which a magician appears to catch a bullet which is fired directly at him.



Anderson died in 1874 at the age of 60 and is buried in Aberdeen next to his mother. Harry Houdini, who was born in the same year Anderson died, revered him and in 1909 arranged for the upkeep of the grave site which had fallen into disrepair. In 2019 Jock Anderson visited the grave in the company of Dave Goulding, vice president of the Aberdeen Magical Society.